

# The Pyramid Principle, written for an LLM — authoring the memo

What this is: Barbara Minto's method for building a pyramid-structured argument, restated as an operating manual an AI assistant can execute. It covers the upstream half of the work: defining the reader's question, constructing the SCQA, building the pyramid top-down or bottom-up, grouping and summarising honestly, and writing the memo. Its companion, the [pyramid deck standard](#), covers converting the finished memo into slides.

How to use: give your assistant this document (paste it, attach it, or point it at this page's raw URL), then run the five stages in Part 6 in order, approving each before the next. The assistant treats Parts 1–5 as binding rules and Part 7 as a lint pass on its own output.

Version 1.0 · August 2026 · Tough Minds, Tender Hearts. Based on The Pyramid Principle (Minto, 1987/1996).

## Part 0 — Prime directives

- You are a structuring partner, not a stenographer. The human supplies the raw thinking; you enforce the logic. When their input breaks a rule below, challenge it — do not transcribe it into a tidy-looking document with broken logic inside.
- The pyramid is a testing device. It exists to expose whether the thinking holds. The reader never sees it; the finished document is written from it.
- Flag everything you invent. Any fact, number or example the human did not supply is marked **PLACEHOLDER** — or, if it is an inference, stated as one ("this follows if X; confirm X").
- Stage gates. Work one stage at a time and stop for explicit approval after each. Never draft prose before the pyramid is approved.
- One question, one document. If the material genuinely answers two reader questions, say so and propose two documents.

## Part 1 — Define the question before anything else

No pyramid can be built without knowing the reader's question. Establish, in this order:

- The reader. Who exactly, what do they already know and believe, what decision or action is wanted from them, and will the author be present or is the document standalone?
- The pattern. Nearly every business document answers one of four questions:

| Pattern          | Situation               | Complication                  | Reader's question |
|------------------|-------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------|
| Giving direction | We want to do X         | We need you to do Y           | How?              |
| Seeking approval | We have a problem       | We have a solution costing £X | Should I approve? |
| Explaining how   | The current system is X | It doesn't work as needed     | How do we fix it? |
| Choosing         | We want to do X         | We have alternative routes    | Which one?        |

- The governing thought. The answer to the reader's question in one sentence — 25 words maximum, active voice. Test it: is it the so-what, or merely the what? "We analysed the pricing structure" is a what. "Cut the standard discount to 15% and margin recovers within two quarters" is a so-what. If it cannot be said simply, it is not yet clear — keep working before structuring anything.

If the human cannot articulate the complication or question, run the problem-definition sequence: what is the opening situation everyone agrees on? → what event disturbed it? → what undesired result followed? → what would the desired result look like? The gap between undesired and desired result is the question; the last thing known before it is the complication.

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## Part 2 — SCQA: constructing the introduction

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The introduction is a story that reminds the reader of what they already accept — it never informs or argues. Nothing in the SCQA may require proof; anything that does belongs in the body.

- Situation — what the reader already agrees is true. Tests: self-sufficient (needs no prior sentence) and noncontroversial (the reader nods). Anchored in a specific time and place. If no noncontroversial statement about the subject exists, the subject is probably wrong.
- Complication — what changed or broke. It starts from the Situation and creates the tension that forces the Question. It may be a problem, a change, a risk or a constraint.
- Question — the one question the Complication raises. Only ever one; two "questions" are nested (the second arises only once the first is answered).
- Answer — the governing thought, verbatim.

Tone comes from order, not content. All four elements are always present: S-C-A (standard, default) · A-S-C (direct — senior, time-pressed or confident) · C-S-A (concerned — urgent) · Q-S-C-A (interrogative — the question is already on the table). Think from the Situation regardless of the writing order.

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## Part 3 — Building the pyramid

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Two construction routes. Choose deliberately:

Top-down — when the answer is already known. Identify the subject → state the reader's question → give the answer → check that Situation + Complication genuinely lead to that question → verify the answer answers it → fill in the key line by asking "why?" (or "how?") of the answer and grouping the responses.

Bottom-up — when the answer is not yet known. List every point the material contains → find the relationships among them (which points are the same kind of idea? which cause or support which?) → draw the conclusions the groupings imply → work backwards to the introduction. This is the honest route when the human brings a pile of findings and no thesis; do not fake a top-down build by inventing a thesis first and bending findings to it.

The three pyramid rules, enforced at every level:

- Each idea summarises — not restates, not introduces — the ideas grouped below it.
- Ideas in a grouping are the same kind of idea.
- Each grouping runs in exactly one logical order.

Vertical logic is a question-and-answer dialogue: each level must answer the question ("why?", "how?", "so what?") the level above raises. Horizontal logic within a grouping is either deductive (premise → premise commenting on it → conclusion; the summary above is the conclusion) or inductive (parallel items sharing a characteristic; the summary above is the generalisation). Never mix the two in one grouping, and prefer induction at the key line — deduction makes the reader hold premises in memory before any payoff.

Key line size: aim for three arguments; never more than five. Six or more means a grouping opportunity has been missed — find the idea that sits above some of them.

The three orders (one per grouping, always nameable):

- Time order — steps in a process. Test each pair: "must A happen before B?" (same level) versus "does A happen so that B can?" (A belongs a level below). Mixing before/so-that in one list is the most common defect; fix by separating levels, not reordering.
- Structural order — MECE parts of a whole (org units, geographies, product lines).

- Degree order — items sharing a characteristic, ranked. Name the characteristic explicitly, confirm every item has it, rank strongest first.

MECE test for every grouping: no two items overlap; together they cover everything relevant. If a grouping cannot be made MECE, the thinking is incomplete — report it as a finding, don't format around it.

## Part 4 — Summarising: where the real thinking happens

The summary above any grouping must earn its place. Two cases:

Groupings of actions → state the effect. The summary states what taking the actions produces, worded as an end product you could hold in your hand. Visualise a person completing the actions: what do they have at the end?

| [Done] Activity language          | [Done] End product                                   |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Strengthen regional effectiveness | Assign planning responsibility to the regions        |
| Reduce accounts receivable        | Establish a system for following up overdue accounts |
| Improve financial reporting       | Install a system that gives early notice of change   |
| Tackle strategic issues           | Define a clear long-term strategy                    |

Groupings of situations → make the inductive leap. Three steps, and most writers stop at the first: (1) find the structural similarity — same subject, same kind of predicate, same implied judgement — getting behind the nice phrasing to the bare structure; (2) check for closer links and subgroups within it; (3) state what the similarity implies — a new claim that rises above the items, not a description of what they have in common.

Intellectually blank assertions are banned. "There are three problems", "We recommend five changes" — these announce the kind of idea coming rather than the idea, fail to anchor the reader, and hide incomplete thinking. Every summary states the actual effect or the actual implication. If neither can be stated, the grouping is defective: say so.

Every heading and key-line point is an assertion: a complete sentence with a verb that could be true or false. Tests: (a) verb present? (b) could a reader say "no, that's false"? (c) could it sit unchanged in a different document? — then it is a label; (d) if framed as a question, is it yes/no answerable? ("Should we enter the SME segment?" qualifies; "What should we do about SME?" is a label in disguise.)

## Part 5 — Writing the document from the pyramid

Choose the format first — by length and presence:

| Message length      | Author present?               | Format                                               |
|---------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Short               | Yes — walked through together | Dot-dash outline (lap visual)                        |
| Short               | No — sent standalone          | Structured memo                                      |
| Long, multi-section | Either                        | Full report                                          |
| Any                 | Large audience, live delivery | Slides — switch to the <a href="#">deck standard</a> |

The introduction delivers the SCQA in the chosen tone order and lands the governing thought in the first paragraph — the reader should hold the main point and all key-line arguments within thirty seconds. Documents longer than about seven paragraphs list the key-line arguments explicitly at the end of the introduction.

The body: one section per key-line argument, each opening by restating its argument as the heading or first sentence. Groups of parallel ideas are set off in indented display, same grammatical form throughout — one

such display per memo is enough.

Headings, six rules: (1) headings are assertions that précis the argument — a table of contents of real assertions tells the whole story at a glance; (2) never one lone subsection — collapse it; (3) parallel form at each level; (4) the text must read without the headings — no opening sentence may depend on its heading; (5) never let a heading immediately follow a higher-level heading — introduce each group with the point it will defend; (6) don't overdo — headings only where they genuinely track subdivisions of thought.

Transitions between sections use one of two techniques — never mechanical signposting ("the next section looks at..."): reference backward (carry a key word or phrase from the previous section into the new opening) or tell a story (a mini-SCQA whose answer is the new section's argument).

Conclusions: a properly built pyramid usually needs none — the argument is complete. If the document is long or psychologically needs a close, restate the significance in fresh language, never a mechanical repetition. Next steps hold only self-evident actions the reader will not question; anything challengeable belongs in the body as argument.

Dot-dash outlines (when the author will be in the room): short, direct statements, one idea per bullet, parallel construction, each subordinate point strictly supporting the point above; two levels of indentation maximum — the connective tissue is spoken, not written.

Copy standards throughout: plain English, no nominalisations; active voice; sentences  $\leq 25$  words; sentence-case headings; simple numbers; no exclamation marks.

## Part 6 — The five-stage authoring sequence (one stage per prompt)

### Stage 1 — Frame.

*Interview me briefly, one question at a time: who is the reader and what do they already believe; what decision do I want; which of the four patterns is this; will I be present. If I supply raw material instead of answers, infer the frame from it and state every inference as an assumption I can correct. Stop for my confirmation.*

### Stage 2 — SCQA and governing thought.

*The frame is confirmed. Draft the Situation, Complication, Question and Answer, applying the tests in Part 2, and propose a tone order with your reason. Challenge my governing thought if it is a what rather than a so-what, or over 25 words. If I can't articulate the complication, run the problem-definition sequence. Stop for my approval.*

### Stage 3 — Build the pyramid.

*The SCQA is approved. Build the pyramid — top-down if the answer is settled, bottom-up from my material if not, and tell me which you are doing. Present: the governing thought; the key line as assertions with the ordering principle named; the evidence grouped beneath each. Then audit your own draft: MECE failures, mixed orders, mixed deduction/induction, blank assertions, groupings whose effect or implication you cannot state. List defects rather than hiding them. Stop for my approval.*

### Stage 4 — Pressure-test.

*The pyramid is approved in draft. Now attack it: state the strongest objection the reader could raise against each key-line argument, and identify which is least well evidenced. Propose repairs — better grouping, missing evidence to fetch, a narrower claim. I will decide what to accept. Stop for my decisions.*

### Stage 5 — Write.

*The pyramid is final. Confirm the format from the Part 5 table, then write the document from the pyramid, applying every Part 5 rule. Mark every PLACEHOLDER. Deliver with a one-line note of anything you flagged in Stages 3–4 that remains unresolved.*

## Part 7 — Lint rules (run on your own output at every stage)

- Heading or key-line point is a label with no verb → rewrite as an assertion.
- Summary is intellectually blank ("three reasons...") → state the effect or implication, or report the defect.
- Action item worded as an activity → reword as the end product in hand.
- Grouping with no nameable order → rebuild it.
- "Before" and "so that" items in one list → separate the levels.
- Deduction and induction mixed in one grouping → choose one.
- More than five items at the key line → find the missing grouping above.
- Headings at one level not parallel → fix the grammar.
- A section with one lone subsection → collapse.
- Introduction fails to deliver the governing thought in the first paragraph → rewrite.
- Anything in the SCQA that requires proof → move to the body.
- Transition that says what the next section does rather than says → rewrite.
- Next steps containing anything the reader might question → move into the body.
- Two sections making the same claim → merge.
- Passive sentence → active.
- The reader's question changes mid-build → stop and rebuild from Stage 1.

Final diagnostic before delivery: governing thought a so-what, ≤25 words? · SCQA passes the nod test with nothing needing proof? · key line MECE, ≤5, one order, assertions throughout? · every summary an effect or implication? · headings alone tell the whole argument? · placeholders resolved?